

Bob Dylan

This section is devoted to that great band of players who write, sing and play their own songs. Here's our tip of the hat to a true legend...



Bob Dylan:
the archetypal
protest singing
folk guitarist

as it was with cut-to-the-quick protest songs that would become essential listening.

We cannot avoid the controversy regarding Bob Dylan 'going electric' in 1965. Where today it seems frankly ridiculous that audiences would be so outraged about an artist plugging in, at the 65 Newport Folk Festival Bob's appearance with an electric guitar was met with vehement boos and Dylan subsequently faced staunch criticism from the folk community, many of whom he had regarded as his friends.

“His powerful rhythm playing serves as the engine room, propelling his compositions along”

Dylan's style is simple, but if you are new to strumming then it's essential you get these techniques in place. There will be subtle touches that can make things tricky for the beginner – quick chord changes or bass notes used to connect chords can confound every guitarist's early ambitions. Even seasoned players can use a strumming brush-up occasionally.

Start off by learning this one very slowly and then try putting it altogether over the backing track. The tempo is fairly brisk and serves to illustrate that, even with simple material, getting it all in place can be a challenge. **SR**

Info Will improve your...

KEY G

TEMPO 95 bpm

- ✓ General strumming
- ✓ Rapid chord changing
- ✓ Overall timekeeping

Bob Dylan is one of a select group of musicians belonging to a pantheon of songwriting 'greats'. While Paul McCartney would sometimes bring the guitar to the fore with fleet finger work on tracks such as *Blackbird*, for Dylan the guitar usually plays more of an accompaniment role via simple strumming patterns – although he can play folk fingerstyle 'Travis' picking guitar with the best of 'em.

As often as not, though, his powerful rhythm playing serves to act as the engine room for his songwriting, propelling his compositions along. It's worth noting that Dylan's acoustic rhythm

playing in many ways defines the American folk sound of the 60s – never intrusive but always solid and serving as a perfect backdrop to the song, its lyrics and melody.

Born Robert Zimmerman on May 24th 1941 in Minnesota, Dylan's early influences were rock and roll artists like Little Richard and Buddy Holly. It was when he went to the University of Minnesota in 1959 that he developed a passion for American folk music, drawn by its melancholy and depth. As with many folk artists of the 1960s, inspiration came in the form of Woody Guthrie (see page 81), whom Dylan befriended. Dylan was also influenced by Ramblin' Jack Elliott and lent his harmonica playing to Elliot's recordings. These associations brought Dylan to the attention of Columbia Records producer John Hammond, and Dylan released his self-titled debut in 1962. However it was 1963's *The Freewheelin' Bob Dylan* that began to bring him attention, laden

Get the tone

Dylan has used a variety of acoustic guitars including Gibson's small-bodied Nick Lucas and jumbo-sized J-200 in the early days. Various Martin models have also figured in the line-up. Any guitar will work fine for these examples, but make sure you strum with conviction – a heavy pick will lend the harder attack most appropriate here; a thinner plectrum provides a softer tone.



LISTENING SUGGESTIONS For Dylan's earlier acoustic work you can't go wrong with *The Freewheelin' Bob Dylan*, which contains the classic *Blowin' In The Wind*. Follow this with 1964's *The Times They Are A Changin'* – his first album to contain all self-penned material. If you want to hear the Dylan influence on The Beatles look no further than the album *Help!* His chord style is all over John Lennon's songs in particular.

EXAMPLE **BOB DYLAN** STYLE

[Bar 1] When changing from the open G to the open C just move the first and second fingers from the G chord and you are left with this lovely Cadd9.

[Bar 6] Another device common to Dylan and acoustic artists of all ages is the descending bassline, in this case the G on the 3rd fret of the sixth string moving to the F# at the 2nd fret and finally to the open sixth string for the Em.

[Bar 8] One to look out for here is how we can 'anticipate' the change from the D to the G by quickly playing this fragmented C chord on the top three strings to ease our movement back into the G chord; it's all about breathing space here. Think of songs like Wonderwall by Oasis or You've Got To Hide Your Love Away by The Beatles to see how these ideas have been adopted and adapted.

[illegible]

EXAMPLE BOB DYLAN STYLE

[Bar 18] This G7 chord shape is something that Dylan himself used and works well with the preceding open G. Make sure you have the correct fingering here – for G, try the third finger of the fretting hand to play the 3rd fret on the sixth string and the fourth finger to fret the first string at the 3rd fret. This will then make the first finger available to G7's F note on the 1st fret, first string.

[Bar 24] A few simple bass notes give some breathing space here; just make sure you are able to play them cleanly and in time before jumping back into the chords. You'll find it's all too easy to rush these things.

[Bar 30] Another simple bass run after the C chord; learning and adapting these runs for all the chords of the open position would be a great idea.

The lesson sheet is divided into five systems, each with a treble clef staff and a corresponding fretboard diagram for the E, B, G, D, A, and E strings. The diagrams include fret numbers and fingering instructions.

- System 1 (Bars 16-18):** Chords D, G, and G7. The G7 diagram shows a specific fingering: 3rd finger on the 3rd fret of the 6th string, 4th finger on the 3rd fret of the 1st string, and 1st finger on the 1st fret of the 1st string.
- System 2 (Bars 19-21):** Chords C, G, and Am. The Am diagram shows a specific fingering: 1st finger on the 1st fret of the 1st string, 2nd finger on the 2nd fret of the 2nd string, 3rd finger on the 3rd fret of the 3rd string, 4th finger on the 4th fret of the 4th string, and 5th finger on the 5th fret of the 5th string.
- System 3 (Bars 22-24):** Chords D7, G, and Cadd9. The D7 diagram shows a specific fingering: 1st finger on the 1st fret of the 1st string, 2nd finger on the 2nd fret of the 2nd string, 3rd finger on the 3rd fret of the 3rd string, 4th finger on the 4th fret of the 4th string, and 5th finger on the 5th fret of the 5th string.
- System 4 (Bars 25-27):** Chords G, Cadd9, and D. The G diagram shows a specific fingering: 3rd finger on the 3rd fret of the 6th string, 4th finger on the 3rd fret of the 1st string, and 1st finger on the 1st fret of the 1st string.
- System 5 (Bars 28-30):** Chords C, Am, C, D, and G. The Am diagram shows a specific fingering: 1st finger on the 1st fret of the 1st string, 2nd finger on the 2nd fret of the 2nd string, 3rd finger on the 3rd fret of the 3rd string, 4th finger on the 4th fret of the 4th string, and 5th finger on the 5th fret of the 5th string.